Valkyries Win WNBA Title in Only Their Second Season

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The Golden State Valkyries defeated the Atlanta Dream 68-63 in a thrilling Game 7 on October 31, 2026, to capture their first WNBA championship. They also made history by becoming the first WNBA **expansion** team to win a title in just their second season.

An **expansion** team is a brand new sports team added to an existing league. It is usually created to bring a team to a city or area that did not previously have one. The San Francisco-based Valkyries joined the WNBA as its 13th team in 2025. In their first season, they won 23 games, more than any other **expansion** team, and became the first **expansion** team to reach the playoffs in their **inaugural** season.

The second year was just as impressive. The team finished the regular season with 32 wins and 12 losses, earning the second **seed** in the playoffs. They then defeated the Dallas Wings in the first round and the defending champion Las Vegas Aces in the **semifinals**. The final against the Atlanta Dream turned into a close battle. After six games, the series was tied at three wins apiece, setting up the first deciding Game 7 in WNBA Finals history.

Trailing by six points at halftime in front of their home crowd at Chase Center, the Valkyries mounted a second-half comeback. Gabby Williams led the effort, scoring 28 points to set a WNBA **postseason** record for the most points in a half. She also made a key three-pointer late in the game, helping Golden State secure the victory. Her outstanding performance earned her the WNBA Finals Most Valuable Player, or MVP, award.

Word Treasure

expansion -- Here, a brand new team added to a sports league.

inaugural -- Happening for the very first time.

seed -- A team's ranking in a playoff, based on how well it played in the regular season.

semifinals -- The round before the final, where the winners go on to play for the championship.

postseason -- The games played after the regular season, also called the playoffs.

Background you need

An expansion team is a new team added to a league, often to bring a sport to a city that did not have a team before.

New teams usually take time to get strong, because they are built from scratch with new players and coaches.

In playoffs, teams play a series of games, and the winner of the series moves on to the next round.

A Game 7 is the last, deciding game of a seven-game series, played when both teams have won three games each.

Break it down

LEAD: The Golden State Valkyries won their first WNBA championship in a thrilling Game 7.

KEY EVENT: They beat the Atlanta Dream 68-63 on October 31, 2026, becoming the first expansion team to win in just their second season.

+- WHO: The San Francisco-based Valkyries, the WNBA's 13th team, led by Gabby Williams.

+- WHEN: Game 7 on October 31, 2026, after a series tied at three wins apiece.

EVIDENCE: Williams scored 28 points, a WNBA postseason record for points in a half, and hit a key late three-pointer.

OPEN QUESTION: The win adds a new chapter to Bay Area basketball history.

Why it matters

A brand new team winning so fast shows that a young team can reach the top quickly, and it gives Bay Area fans a new championship team to cheer.

Test what you remember

1. **What was the final score of Game 7?**
   - (A) 70-60 to Golden State
   - (B) 63-68 to Atlanta
   - (C) 68-68, a draw
   - (D) 68-63 to Golden State
2. **When did the Valkyries win their first WNBA championship?**
   - (A) October 31, 2026
   - (B) In 2004
   - (C) In 2025
   - (D) In their first season
3. **What record did the Valkyries set as an expansion team?**
   - (A) First expansion team to reach the playoffs
   - (B) First expansion team to win a title in just their second season
   - (C) First team to win 100 games
   - (D) First team to play in San Francisco
4. **How many games did the Valkyries win in their first season?**
   - (A) 12
   - (B) 32
   - (C) 23
   - (D) 13
5. **Who did the Valkyries beat in the semifinals?**
   - (A) The Seattle Storm
   - (B) The defending champion Las Vegas Aces
   - (C) The Dallas Wings
   - (D) The Atlanta Dream
6. **Who was named WNBA Finals MVP after scoring 28 points, a postseason record for points in a half?**
   - (A) The Valkyries coach
   - (B) Keisha Lance Bottoms
   - (C) A Las Vegas player
   - (D) Gabby Williams

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):